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POLITICS

“Have Spoken Ill of Him in Life, Will Continue to Do So in Death” – Leftist Youth Group Slams ‘Posthumous Veneration’ of Ratan Tata by Foreign & National Press

As politicians and press commemorated Ratan Tata's death with state funeral proposals and Bharat Ratna nominations, COLLECTIVE Delhi released a statement refusing to observe the silence demanded by mourning — recounting the Tata Group's documented history of forceful land acquisition and labour suppression that his philanthropic image was built to obscure.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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“On one hand, to ideologically defend their profit-based system, Tata Steel has established institutions like the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) and Tata Environment Research Institute (TERI) using their financial clout; on the other hand, to pit the oppressed against each other, private militias like Salwa Judum and Operation Green Hunt have been funded by houses like Tata and Jindal.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

COLLECTIVE Delhi Secretary Sourya's statement recounts the Tata Group's long history of forceful land acquisition & human rights violations, calling out the selective memory & revisionist narrative of Tata's posthumous virtue being put forth by the media in the wake of his death.

13th October 2024, New Delhi: With the demise of industrial giant & 5th generation heir of the Tata Group on October 9th, 2024, Ratan N. Tata, the late tycoon has quickly become a global symbol of ethical entrepreneurship & philanthropy, being hailed as a visionary by foreign governments & local critics alike. But in a world where mourning & condolence come tied to social conventions & speaking 'ill of the dead' is avoided like a totem cursed with the worst curses of them all (being frowned upon), it can become difficult to tell the grief apart from the spectacle. Certainly it is safe to say, that when it comes to the press, grief *is* spectacle¹.

As VIPs spent the last 48 hours celebrating the life & mourning the loss of Tata – who died of natural causes on Wednesday morning at the age of 86 – to immense media attention, one side of the coin that has been wholistically ignored by mainstream as well as large parts of independent media is that of the Tata Group's political history, one that is fraught with violence and controversy. In the cacophony of mournful obituaries & funeral telecasts² drowning out any and all counternarratives from the newssphere, one demographic that is sustaining a quiet, consistent voice of dissent, is the youth. Whether through student representatives or through digital apparatuses³, the young left has held onto its views on Tata, intent on highlighting the group's bloody history.

As the country's press covers which celebrities were seen in attendance of Tata's (Twitter) funeral, which 23 of his quotes make the best compilation, & writes a headline for every person – from a newspaper vendor⁴ to Amitabh Bachchan – that can offer a quote of condolences for the tycoon, young journalists, digital media influencers, & left-wing student organisations in their infancy have been unflinching in their continued critique of the less picturesque aspects of the Tata Group's evolution. This is the first of a series of articles that hopes to uphold, even if only microscopically, the desperate & delicate balance of news that the Indian press today has seemed to forsake. Here's charting the other side of the coin.

As in life, so in death.

Left, Right & Centre: Was Tata Beloved By All?

In a statement^[1] to its members on Wednesday, following the barrage of digital news articles & political announcements marking Tata's demise as a tragic loss to the nation, leftist youth organisation COLLECTIVE's Delhi General Secretary, Sourya observed that the mournful camp in the event of Tata's death had seemingly united people from diametric ends of the political spectrum. "Today, the 'leftist' Chief Minister of Kerala and a billionaire from Gujarat are both paying tribute to Ratan Tata. It is a matter of great pride for any individual when ideological opponents come together in mourning, but this reflects something deeper," it opens.

"Today, the 'leftist' Chief Minister of Kerala and a billionaire from Gujarat are both paying tribute to Ratan Tata. It is a matter of great pride for any individual when ideological opponents come together in mourning, but this reflects something deeper." — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

This is in reference to tweets⁵ by CPI(M)'s Pinarayi Vijayan and businessman Gautam Adani respectively. Vijayan was elected Kerala's Chief Minister as well as the leader of the Left Democratic Front back in 2016⁶, two positions he has held since, & is among the country's most prominent of leftist voices. Gautam Adani, on the other hand, is the most powerful name backing the Indian right wing at time of writing, whose rise to becoming the second richest man in India paralleled incumbent Prime Minister Narendra Modi's political rise from a controversial Gujarati CM struggling with a PR crisis to being elected leader of the executive for three consecutive terms after he extended financial support to him in the aftermath of the *Godhrā Kānd*⁷. Indeed, the two could not be further apart in terms of what they represent to the ideological Indian, & yet both seem to have come together in writing X (formerly Twitter) eulogies for Tata.

This dichotomy, between right, left & Tata, is not an isolated & interesting case study of human multitudes, but something that has remained ever-present throughout the partly fabled tale of the Tata Group's 200-year⁸ tumultuous history. Tata's institutions & architectures have long defined the murky space of the Indian political centre, having been founded as a business empire that formed the very blueprint of industry in a mixed economy. As India's economy has shifted away from the part-socialist model to an increasingly capitalist one, the conglomerate's constitution has similarly evolved. Yet even in 2024, in the steel rods that hold up this country & in the military vehicles that surveil it, the dichotomy survives.

Bastar, Tata Steel, & The 'Biggest Land Grab Since Columbus'

While Adani's posthumous reverence of Tata has been called out by veteran journalist Ravish Kumar & popular consensus⁹, it is Vijayan's support that truly stands out. COLLECTIVE itself is a leftist organisation, & the handful of other media houses that have expressed dissent thus far – a list which at time of writing is limited to TVE & The Caravan¹⁰ – are left-leaning. Part of this is intuitive, as Tata was, ultimately, the chairperson of a multibillion-dollar industrial empire, & at that, one that has had a history of financing political parties at the centre¹¹ in exchange for legal favours (see 13). But the left's contention with Tata extends far past ideology, with the conglomerate's history of workers' safety violations¹² & forceful land acquisition¹³ having stained the conglomerate's long arms in blood.

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Salwa Judum (2005-11) & Operation Green Hunt¹⁴ (2009-10) were government-sanctioned paramilitary forces deployed to counter-insurgency operations across India in the late 2000s against 'Naxalite forces' along various state borders. Today, both operations are remembered as dark chapters in Indian history, having been widely denounced by human rights organisations as well as the Supreme Court of India itself after they resulted in the deaths of thousands of Adivasis at the hands of poorly trained youth – 12,000 of whom in the SJ were revealed to be minors – & irreversibly changed the state of the tribal land they infiltrated with their brutality, many of which like Bastar are still paying the price.

This is merely one of the numerous cases of controversy enumerated in Sourya's full statement¹⁵, not to mention countless others that have entered the public sphere & quietly disappeared over the last two centuries, all of which are easily verifiable, & TVE encourages readers to do so themselves in this age of information & internet access.

“The memorial for 13 martyrs in Kalinga Nagar, Odisha, remains a proud symbol of tribal resistance [against Tata Steel]. When the country’s first ‘Special Economic Zone’ was established in Bengal during the CPI(M) regime in 2003, Tata [was among] its first consumers. In Singur and Nandigram, landless and small farmers were forcibly evicted from their land [by the government for Tata’s Nano plant]. In 2015, when demands for a union arose against falling real wages, union leadership was illegally ousted. [...] Tea plantation workers who grow Tata Tea are now facing the police to unite in Darjeeling. From Kashmir to Manipur and Nagaland, Tata trucks and drones are merely another name for military rule.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

Censorship, Palestine, & Institutional ideology

The comparison to Jindal above holds true for Tata in another, even more damning sense. While both groups hide their investment in militant violence & unlawful land acquisition – an ordinary procedure in the industries of steel & power – behind philanthropy & founding educational institutes, the flagship institutions of both groups have come under fire in the past year for controversies relating to censorship of scholars & student groups¹⁵. While Jindal’s offices issued ‘warnings’ to faculty in the academic sphere for speaking on the escalating violence in Palestine, TISS went as far as formally banning a leftist student organisation, the Progressive Student’s Forum¹⁶.

“This notice addresses a critical issue concerning the presence of an unauthorised and illegal forum on our campuses, reportedly the ‘PSF TISS’. This group has been engaging in activities that obstruct the institute’s functions, defame the institute, demean members of our community, and create divisions among students and faculty. It has been observed that this group is misleading, distracting and misguiding students from their academic pursuit and harmonious life in the campus. (sic)” — Order by the Office of Registrar, Anil Sutar, Tata Institute of Social Sciences, 19th August 2024 (as reported by Hindustan Times^[31])

Such orders have been on the rise all across India’s higher education institutes, a large number of whom – as rightly being pointed out by independent creators like Dhruv Rathee & Ravish Kumar – have been quietly founded by the Tata Group all along, even those that don’t have ‘Tata’ in the name¹⁷. Certainly, if the higher educational institutes founded by corporations serve as representations of their & their leader’s thoughts, Tata has time and again made clear where it stands, against the left, if not quite all the way on the right¹⁸.

But institutional ideology & administrative decisions come in handy for little more than speculation regarding their leaders' philosophies. A much stronger tool for silent diplomacy in modern geopolitics, is trade¹⁹, and when it comes to issues like the Palestinian Genocide, the Tata Group has taken an extremely explicit political stance with its supply of Range Rovers to the Israeli Military for use in the Occupied West Bank²⁰.

In the Murky Middle: Revisionist History & PR

Readers at this point in the article, have they not been keeping up with the news, may find themselves confused with this statement. After all, when there is genocide – several counts thereof – on one's resume, what ambiguity can there be?

The unflashy answer, in the 21st century, is plenty. Truth & agendas in the era of mass communication are largely decided by the elusive & opaque functionings of the press, always a cross between reality & PR, always a less than straightforward concoction of man & machine. There are several parts of Tata's well-kempt public profile that are designed to keep it that way, & they do so efficiently. Ratan Tata's love for dogs²¹, for instance, is an idea that has burrowed deep into the Indian newsreader's consciousness over years & years of generous & repeated media coverage. Tata Steel's involvement in the Bastar violence on the other hand is something no amount of Google searching will reveal to anyone who doesn't already know where to look.

Beyond the effectiveness of revisionist narratives, there is also the philosophical conundrum of the 'corporate identity.' A large part of why corporate giants like Nestle, Amazon & Tata are able to maintain an acceptable image to the average consumer across the world despite the open secrets of their large-scale controversies & gross human rights violations is because this corporate identity bears the bulk of the real world legal & ethical impact, while the thousands of 'real people' behind it get to split the societal judgement between them till its negligible in consequence. This is why no matter how surprised you are at what new horrifying thing Nestle's management said in court today²², you will be just as surprised when it does it again tomorrow. The corporate identity is the rhetorical armour that protects big businesses from accountability, & it has an infinite capacity for shock absorption.

On the one hand, Tata Steel's MoU with the state of Chhattisgarh involved the signing of a Rs. 10,000 cr. contract for tribal land that would be acquired through the mass killing of tribals by government-employed child soldiers²³, but it was not Ratan Tata who hired them. It was not Ratan Tata who fired the gun. It is not Ratan Tata who pushed employees into vats of steel on a semi-regular basis in his factories or gave speeches against unionisation & worker's rights. In 2015, the BJP government in Chhattisgarh revoked Tata's licence²⁴ over the land it stole from Bastar due to its continued delay in building the steel plant that it had all been for. What is the ideology that one should extract here?

It is this necessitated speculation that breeds ambiguity. There is no 'source' telling us which of these decisions were his & what his stances were regarding each one, & it is possible there never will be. Tata's love for dogs & concern for the middle class on the other hand is verifiably his own. In his own voice & word, conveniently amplified by the media, is the image of a man who 'donated himself out of billionaire lists' & flew economy by choice. It is no wonder that people from every strata & ideology queued outside his funeral to get one last glimpse of Ratan Tata's enshrined body; it is the only look at the man they ever got.

Effective Altruism & Funeral Politics: The Ethics of Philanthropy

Ravish Kumar's 24-minute bulletin^[4] in tribute to Ratan Tata highlights his firmly pacifist stance during the 26/11 attacks on the Tata Group-owned Taj Hotel in an atmosphere of rising anti-Pakistan & anti-Muslim sentiment. As Sourya points out in his statement, silence in times of polarisation is in itself a statement of complicity, & Tata's silence at the time was antagonistic to the Indian right-wing, spearheaded by the Bajrang Dal & RSS – who were later accused of having orchestrated the attacks after the assassination of Hemant Karkare²⁵.

Though this article is meant to focus on the less-than-shiny aspects of the late businessman's life, considering the other is more than made up for by mainstream media, this brief tangent is crucial in understanding that it is not only the left today whose diplomatic grief is laced with salt. Even those of India's conservative right who were in this regard opposed by Tata have changed their tune about him today. Maharashtra's incumbent CM, Shiv Sena's Eknath Shinde, has left no stone unturned in displaying his utmost devotion to the tycoon through 'state honoured' last rites & promises of posthumous honour, cleverly omitting the fact that the man he has announced a Bharat Ratna award for in his death was vocally against^[5] receiving one in his life.

One of the main defences being employed by the present press narrative exalting Tata is his notable lack of billionaire status. Times Now, Business Standard, India TV & Firstpost each²⁶ released an article on 10th October 2024 on how despite the multibillion-dollar empire he built in the time he oversaw the family conglomerate, Ratan Tata never made it to a billionaire's list.

"How is it possible that someone who has been at the helm of the country's largest business conglomerate for six decades (sic) is not in the list of the top 10 or top 20 richest individuals in the country? Yet, this is a fact. The reason for this can also be the large-scale philanthropic work done by the Tata family through the Tata Trust. In fact, the Tata family members traditionally hold minimal personal stakes in their own companies. Jamsetji Tata, the founder of the Tata Group, established a guiding principle that much of the profits earned by Tata Sons should be donated to the Tata Trust for philanthropic purposes. The Tata family has been a pioneer in philanthropic work much before people like Bill Gates." —Arushi Jaiswal, 10th October 2024, India TV, "Ratan Tata, who built a million-dollar empire, never made it to any billionaires list"

Above is a quote from an India TV article that showcases not only the worrying & discreditable state of mainstream journalism but also the strange atmosphere of the current media narrative surrounding Tata. Beyond the irony of lauding a business veteran's lack of billionaire status as virtuous by corporate owned, government favouring media houses less than 5 months after the country's Prime Minister asked a roundtable of journalists if, "everybody should be poor?"^[61]²⁷ – what is being heavily implied in these headlines is a school of ethical philosophy called, "effective altruism," where an individual aims to accumulate wealth for the purpose of philanthropy, attempting to optimise the 'good' of the latter as the end which justifies any possible 'bad' means of the prior.

'Effective altruism' in the name emerged as a fringe neo-philosophical movement in 2009, & has since undergone a dramatic rise & fall in both popularity & credibility after Sam Bankman Fried – one of the movement's central figures – was accused and later convicted of crypto fraud last year^[71]; but the philosophy itself isn't exactly new. Its disgraced founder,²⁸ William McAskill, merely algorithmised & gave a name to what has always been the main tenet of all philanthropic ethic: In direct opposition to the popular proverb from the Hippocratic Oath, the very idea of 'earning-to-give' is premised upon first causing harm, then offsetting it via donation. In her video^[81] on effective altruism, YouTuber and thespian Abigail Thorn explains this phenomenon:

“Several years ago I was invited to be the ethics consultant at a banking conference. They put me on a business class flight to a luxury hotel in Madrid, [where] over several days, I and the other attendees discussed how we could fix the various problems facing the world: healthcare, debt, financial collapse. [...] Conferences like that are held all the time. At the top end you’ve got stuff like the World Economic Forum, the Clinton Global Initiative and the Social Good Summit; further down the list is the thing that I went to. Rich people have been trying to figure out the most effective way to get rid of their money for a long time.” — Abigail Thorn, 25th February 2023, The Rich Have Their Own Ethics: Effective Altruism & the Crypto Crash (ft. F1nn5ter)^[8], @PhilosophyTube on YouTube

The video goes on to trace the downfall of the effective altruism movement, which by 2015, coming back to Tata, had itself grown into a multibillion dollar project^[9]. Finishing her anecdote about the banking conference she was invited to, Thorn says, “[When the last day finally] came, I closed out the conference by giving my keynote speech. And my ethical advice to all these bankers was that they should immediately resign.”

Conclusion

“It is said that one should not criticise a person after their death. Well, even during Ratan Tata’s lifetime, we have spoken ill of him and will continue to do so; a life of luxury and comfort tends to reflect a certain soft sensitivity and generosity on a person’s face. A hungry child, writhing with hunger, may grab his brother’s collar and say, “Give me food, you bastard.” It takes centuries and billions of wealth for newly emerged capitalists, who flee their society after violence, to achieve such an innocent image.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

It cannot be discounted when remembering the legacy of Ratan Tata that it is as much one of covert abuse, extremism, & violence as it is that of effective altruism, & neither aligns with the interests or ideologies of the public figures that are venerating him today. Like the Bharat Ratna, all the grief that politicians, journalists, & public figures from either side are extending to Ratan. N. Tata today, is meant more for them than it is for him.

Funerals, after all, are for the living.

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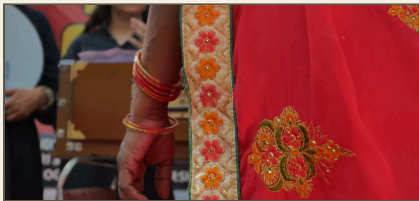
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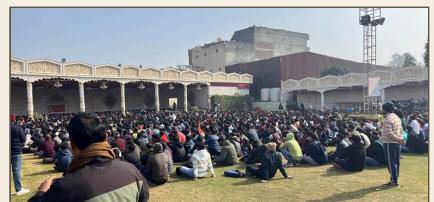
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